



GAME-SPECIFIC FACULTY GUIDE

Megastar Mania

A concert-tour game built around price, demand, capacity, and fan access.

Why This Game Exists

In designing Megastar Mania, I wanted supply and demand to feel like something students had probably watched happen before. An artist starts with a modest following, releases a hit, adds shows, loses dates, upsets fans, and tries to reach a new audience. Students manage that career first. The formal economics can come afterward.

Supply-and-demand exercises often ask about one isolated change. Jules Arlen's career gives students a continuing story: a price that fits the early audience may leave fans outside after a hit, and a larger tour may have empty seats when interest fades. Later, you can ask which events moved a curve and which changed purchases along it. Students have a musician, fans, and decisions to explain.

What Students Do

Students take the role Tour Manager • Jules Arlen. Jules is a fictional indie-pop singer with a modest following. A run takes about 10–15 minutes and includes six decisions across the career and successive booking windows.

They set a premium, moderate, or introductory opening price. When a single breaks out, they keep that price or raise it moderately or sharply. Promoters then offer extra dates or larger venues; students can also keep the schedule limited. Laryngitis interrupts the tour, forcing cancellations, postponement beyond the current window, or a longer recovery break. After Jules returns, a careless interview weakens interest. Students respond to the remark, then choose the original sound, a limited crossover, or full crossover appeal.

Each choice brings a consequence and an economic tradeoff. Prices remain in force after the breakout decision, shaping the market through later events. The venue represents the tour across booking windows. At the end, students review their path, read the economics, and work through a graph and two applications. Seven unranked endings reflect their earlier price, capacity, audience, and career choices. A compact tour can be deliberate even with strong interest; open seats may reflect a high retained price. Ask what produced the student's ending and what they gave up along the way.

Reading the tour conditions

Fan Interest describes enthusiasm for Jules, and Ticket Supply describes available seats and performances. Both use qualitative labels. Tour Revenue tracks receipts after refunds; Fan Goodwill and Career Momentum describe broader career conditions. These three retain 0–8 displays, with no combined score to maximize.

The Ticket Market gauge compares requests at the posted price with available seats to show shortage, balance, or surplus. Price affects how many fans seek tickets, so the Fan Interest and Ticket Supply labels alone cannot tell you the market result. The gauge summarizes that comparison without measuring the size of the gap.

What the Game Is Really Teaching

Jules can face empty seats or shut-out fans before anything has changed about the music. With the same modest following and venue, premium pricing leaves tickets unsold, a moderate price matches requests to capacity, and an introductory price brings more requests than seats. Buyers respond to the posted price while their underlying enthusiasm stays the same. You can return to these opening choices when explaining movement along a demand curve.

Once the single breaks out, that earlier price meets a larger audience. More listeners want tickets at a given price: demand has shifted right. Ask students to separate what the song did from their response as manager. Keeping the price lets more fans seek the limited seats; raising it moves quantity demanded along the new curve. A sharp increase after a premium opening can still leave tickets unsold despite the hit.

Where requests exceed capacity, some fans miss out and resale offers rise above the official price. Those offers reveal additional willingness to pay, with the premium going to resellers rather than Jules. A sellout alone tells you only that every ticket sold; the fans still trying to buy establish the shortage. It is a useful moment to ask how an affordable official price can help successful buyers while leaving others competing for access.

Promoters can make room for more fans through extra dates or larger venues. Both expand supply, leaving underlying interest unchanged. Whether the added seats sell depends on the price students retained and the buyers still seeking tickets. Laryngitis then takes opportunities away: canceled performances and dates postponed beyond the current window are unavailable now, although fans' interest remains. Refunds weaken receipts, and protecting recovery time means giving up current shows. Jules eventually returns to the remaining dates; the removed capacity stays removed. Expansion and illness give you a pair of supply shifts to compare within the same career.

With the remaining performances back on, the interview brings a different problem. Seats and price stay fixed while listeners lose interest; an apology softens the decline more than silence. A small remaining tour can still sell out, even after that fall in demand. The crossover offers a way to reach new listeners again. A limited collaboration or full crossover shifts demand right, while keeping the original sound leaves it unchanged. Students can trace these opposing audience responses without adding or removing a single seat.

That fixed schedule matters when they interpret the release. New listeners can fill empty seats, but a tour already selling every ticket has no further room for them. Stronger demand then increases scarcity without raising sales or receipts at the retained price. Bring the discussion back to what students managed: access, ticket receipts, fan relationships, and Jules's future. The price choices illustrate tensions among those priorities, without estimating elasticity or identifying a revenue-maximizing price.

Reading the Concert Scenes

Compare the opening surplus and shortage. Jules performs in both scenes. On the left, seats remain open; on the right, a full venue still leaves fans outside. A different price can produce these conditions with the same underlying following and capacity.



Surplus, left, and shortage, right. Empty seats and shut-out fans reveal the gap between requests and capacity at the posted price.

Elsewhere, the tour map shows expanded capacity and the closed venue shows supply lost to illness. Weaker and stronger crowds help students follow changes in the audience. Ask them to explain the image using their decision and the Ticket Market gauge: what changed, and what stayed fixed?

The Educational Loop

Career choices lead to consequences and explanations. The four-part debrief brings together surplus and shortage, sellouts and resale, supply changes, and demand changes. A graph formalizes the final market; two applications and replay carry the reasoning into another setting. The applications provide feedback and retries before completion.

Experience → Consequence → Economic Explanation → Formalization → Transfer

Bringing in the Supply-and-Demand Graph

By the time you draw the graph, students have experienced both curves moving. To sketch it together first, ask them to pause at the outcome before Here is what economists draw. The six management decisions use no graphs or algebra.

1. Start with Jules's early tour. Put ticket price vertically and quantity horizontally. Draw downward-sloping demand and vertical supply for the seats available in that booking window.
2. Try another posted price with both curves fixed. Read quantity demanded along demand and compare it with capacity: $Q_d > Q_s$ means shortage, $Q_d = Q_s$ means balance, and $Q_d < Q_s$ means surplus.
3. Let the hit shift demand right. Then add the student's price response as movement along the new curve. Which change came from listeners, and which from the manager?
4. Use extra dates or larger venues to shift supply right, and illness to shift it left. Keep demand fixed through those changes.
5. Bring in the interview, shifting demand left. A limited or full crossover shifts it right again; keeping the original sound leaves it unchanged.
6. Finish with the student's final price, requests, and remaining seats. Ask why more demand can deepen a shortage without increasing sales when capacity already binds.

The closing diagram matches the final shortage, balance, or surplus, using fixed remaining capacity. Keep the discussion of goodwill, momentum, and receipts alongside that market picture. Ask students to support it with evidence from their path.

Using It in Class

These are possible starting points; choose what fits your course.

Before formal instruction

Let students manage Jules before introducing the graph. Ask what caused empty seats, queues, added capacity, and weaker crowds. Build the diagram from their accounts, separating price decisions from changes in the audience.

During or after instruction

During instruction, pause at a career event and ask students to classify it before drawing. Afterward, have them annotate a completed path with price-driven movements, demand shifts, and supply shifts. Use a sellout to ask whether all buyers were served and who receives a resale premium.

Replay and comparison

Record the first path, then change a price choice while keeping later capacity and audience decisions the same. Or retain the price path and change capacity. Predict the effect, compare the two markets, and explain the difference through requests and available seats. The comparison tests a mechanism; it need not identify a preferred career.

Independent/student review

The career, debrief, and applications also work for independent review. Replay scenario starts a fresh run. You can request an ending screenshot plus one supply-shift and one demand-shift explanation through your course workflow; the game provides no automatic faculty report.

Questions to Consider

Select any of these prompts for discussion or a short reflection.

1. Jules begins with the same audience and venue. How can a different price produce empty seats or shut-out fans while Fan Interest stays unchanged?
2. What changed when the breakout song reached new listeners? Separate that change from the effect of your next price decision.
3. Why do extra dates or larger venues shift supply? Under what conditions would those added seats actually increase tickets sold?
4. How can laryngitis increase scarcity while Fan Interest stays the same? Why are postponed performances outside this window unavailable now?
5. What can a sellout tell you, and what additional evidence establishes a shortage? Use the scene and Ticket Market gauge.
6. What does resale above the official price reveal about buyers' willingness to pay? Who receives that extra payment?
7. How can a crossover increase demand without increasing tickets sold or receipts? Explain the role of remaining capacity.
8. On replay, change either price or capacity while keeping the other decisions as similar as possible. Which differences came from movement along demand, and which came from a curve shifting?

Common Misconceptions

- “A higher ticket price means demand increased.” A price change alters quantity demanded along a demand curve. The breakout changes the underlying demand relationship; repricing responds to it.
- “Sold out means requests exactly matched supply.” All seats sold, but more buyers may remain. Look for shut-out fans and the gauge's shortage reading.
- “Adding dates increases demand, and illness reduces it.” Both change current ticket supply in this game. Fan Interest stays unchanged through those decisions.
- “More Fan Interest automatically produces more sales and receipts.” Fans respond to the retained price, and sales are capped by available seats. Extra demand at an already sold-out schedule intensifies scarcity.
- “The artist receives the resale premium.” Resellers receive the extra payment. Jules's Tour Revenue tracks official receipts after refunds.
- “A smaller tour or open seats proves weak interest.” A compact schedule can be deliberate. Strong interest can also coexist with unsold seats at a high retained price.

These conditions are instructional, with no real ticket counts, actual dollar receipts, or calibrated demand estimates. Tour Revenue describes receipts after refunds, not profit.

General teaching and implementation resources are available at [Mastery Quests Faculty Resources](#).